

SHUTTERSTOCK

Watching Autumn Leaves Fall

Since summer gives way to winter in our cities almost without warning, not many Indians, sadly, are familiar with the joys of autumn. If, however, you wanted those seasons of extreme hot and cold to have a hyphen, simply head to Kashmir between late September and November. Beyond the kahwa and shikaras, Srinagar offers you the rare sight of chinar trees shedding autumnal leaves. The chinar was introduced to Kashmir by the Mughals, and it is, in many ways, the cynosure of Srinagar's iconic gardens. During '**Harud**' (**the Kashmiri name for autumn**), places like Shalimar and Naseem Bagh are all carpeted with brown leaves that crunch and crackle under one's feet.

If Srinagar is all about the brown, Shillong is all about the pink. Cherry trees that were planted in the city in the mid-1970s are now one of its prime attractions. While social media is often awash with pictures of couples and tourists posing against the blazing pink trees, authorities attempt a more formal celebration with the annual **Shillong Cherry Blossom Festival**. Though the main festival will take place from November 24-26, preliminary events kick off on October 15.



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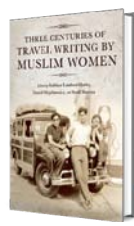
FROM COVER TO COVER

New travel literature to pack along with your bags



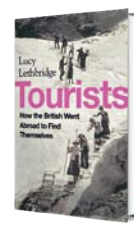
BETWEEN HEAVEN AND EARTH: Writings on the Indian Hills
by Ruskin Bond and Bulbul Sharma (editors)
Speaking Tiger
₹699; 432 pages

Ruskin Bond lives in Mussoorie, while Bulbul Sharma spends some of her time in Shaya, a Himachali village. Together, they bring to this anthology their honed knowledge about India's hills.



THREE CENTURIES OF TRAVEL WRITING BY MUSLIM WOMEN
by Siobhan Lambert-Hurley, Daniel Majchrowicz, and Sunil Sharma (editors)
Indiana University Press
₹6,154; 534 pages

This travel writing collection by Muslim women from past centuries is a treat to read. It also shows us that one does not need wealth or the entitlement of masculinity to explore the world.



TOURISTS: How the British Went Abroad to Find Themselves
by Lucy Lethbridge
Bloomsbury
₹799; 362 pages

Not all Britons travelled abroad to colonise countries. In this thorough exploration of British tourism, Lucy Lethbridge shows how travel can both destroy and preserve traditional cultures.

Keeping it Simple

Last year, the town of **Vythiri in Kerala's Wayanad district** became India's first fully vaccinated tourism destination. Known for its forests, spice plantations, and tribal communities, the town again made news this July when Mahindra Group chairman Anand Mahindra posted a video about it with the caption, "Kudos to Kerala Tourism for this concept. The pristine architectural design of the village is stunning. Showcases how 'simplicity' can be stunning." He was referring to the 'En Uru' tribal heritage hamlet project, which offers authentic tribal food and the chance to shop in a tribal market.

